

Collective Intelligence — Module 02: Agents —

Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on individual vs. collective agency, distributed cognition, and conditions for collective intelligence.

1. How does collective agency emerge from individual agency? Is it always greater than the sum of its parts, or can collective action be worse than individual action?
2. Woolley et al. (2010) found that team IQ depends more on social sensitivity than individual intelligence. Why would social sensitivity matter more than raw cognitive ability?
3. Why does "social loafing" occur more in large groups than small ones? How does Active Inference explain the incentive structure?
4. How does Hutchins' concept of "distributed cognition" change how we think about organizational intelligence? If the cockpit "remembers" speed, who is the agent?
5. Compare a surgical team and a software development team. What aspects of collective agency are similar? What differs due to time pressure, reversibility, and task structure?
6. Status hierarchy effects cause high-status members' views to dominate. Design a team process that weights evidence quality over speaker status.
7. Knowledge hiding — members withholding information for competitive advantage — undermines collective intelligence. What incentive structures promote or prevent it?
8. How does team diversity (cognitive, demographic, experiential) contribute to collective intelligence? When can diversity hurt rather than help?
9. Describe the difference between a team with distributed cognition and a team where one person does all the thinking. What are the advantages and disadvantages of each?

10. How does a team's collective agency change when it transitions from co-located to fully remote? What coordination mechanisms compensate for the loss of physical proximity?
11. Identify the specialized roles in a team you know well. What happens if one specialist is absent? How resilient is the team's distributed cognition?
12. A team consistently underperforms despite having highly talented individual members. Diagnose this using the pathologies of collective agency. Which pathology is most likely?
13. Design a meeting format that maximizes collective intelligence. Address equal participation, independence of judgment, and diverse perspectives.
14. How would you onboard a new member into a team's distributed cognition system? What knowledge transfer is needed beyond task-specific training?
15. Compare how collective agency functions in a jazz ensemble versus an orchestra. Map each to organizational team types.
16. A team has developed strong collective agency over 2 years. A reorganization splits the team. What is lost, and how long would it take to rebuild?
17. How does tool use (shared software, collaborative platforms) extend collective cognition? Is a team's intelligence partly in its tools?
18. When should an organization dissolve a high-performing team to distribute its knowledge more broadly? What is the trade-off?
19. How does the concept of "psychological safety" (Edmondson) relate to collective agency? Why is it necessary for team intelligence?
20. Design a diagnostic that measures collective intelligence (not just individual team satisfaction). What tasks or exercises would reveal the team's actual collective capability?